

NO TEARS FOR OSCAR

Quibbling over which film India sends to the Academy Awards is not as important as getting the film nominated over stiff competition from 50 other nations. And then winning.

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

The sheer entertainment generated by the controversy surrounding India's official entry to the Oscars in the foreign language film category has far outstripped that provided either by *Eklavya: The Royal Guard* or by the film that has challenged it, *Dharm*. The name-calling between the two filmmakers, Vidhu Vinod Chopra and Bhavna Talwar, and even third parties unconnected to the whole drama, can only be described as delicious. While Chopra has declared that the controversy is "spoiling" India's image internationally, first-time filmmaker Talwar has pronounced that her film *Dharm* went to

the Cannes Film Festival in the Cinema of the World section. She omits to mention it was accompanied by six other Indian films, among them Mani Ratnam's *Guru* and Rituparno Ghosh's *Dosar*, while director Sajid Khan has said the entire box office collection of Chopra's oeuvre could fit into the pocket of his debut film, *Heyy Babyy*.

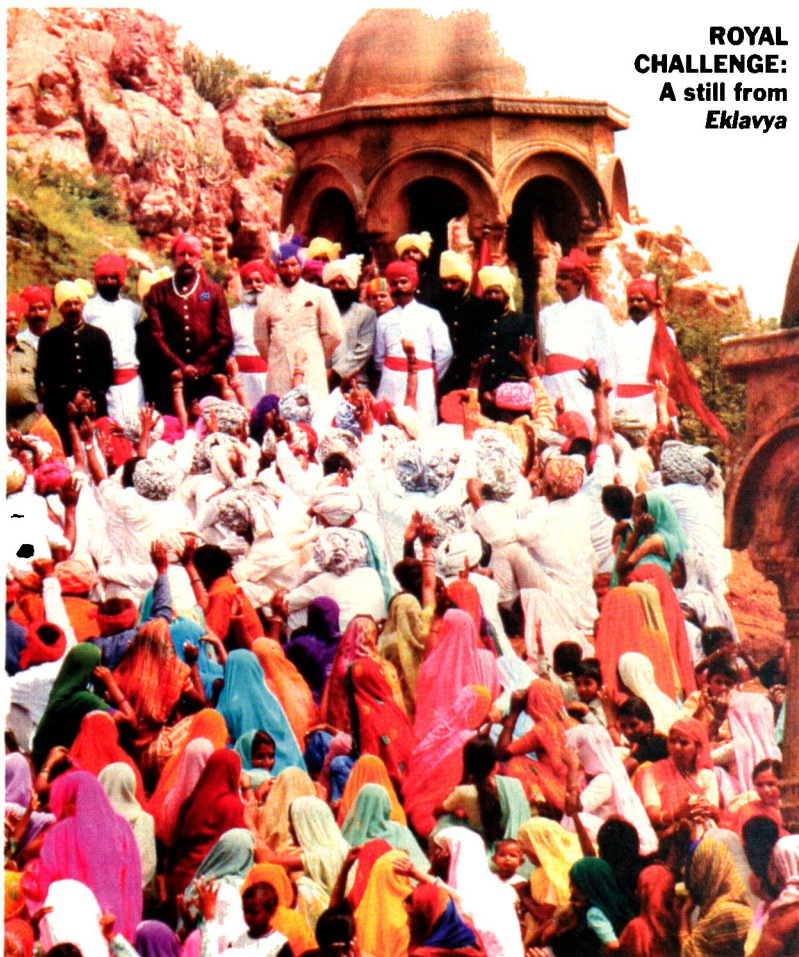
The courts have stepped in and prevented some more verbal fireworks—a division bench of the Bombay High Court has prima facie found a case for bias and will hear the matter on October 10—but the larger question remains. Given that India has been nominated in the foreign film category only thrice (for *Mother India* in 1957, *Salaam Bombay* in 1988 and *Lagaan* in

2001), does it really matter? The short answer is yes. The Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences (AMPAS), an organisation comprising 6,000 motion picture craftsmen, still hands out the most respected and coveted film award in the world. The long answer is that India doesn't know the first thing of how to go about winning it. Most choices happen by chance. The film is selected by a jury appointed by the Film Federation of India (FFI), which is meant to represent all the organisations connected with the industry across all regions. It isn't completely representative (for instance, the powerful Film and Television Producers' Guild of India, among whose members are Yash Chopra, Ashutosh Gowariker and



VIDHU VINOD CHOPRA
Director, *Eklavya*

Nadeem Khan is a member of the jury and one of my oldest friends. He voted for Bhawna Talwar's film.



ROYAL CHALLENGE:
A still from *Eklavya*



BHAVNA TALWAR
Director, *Dharm*

It's all about personal agenda. If we send *Eklavya*, the Academy will say we don't know how to make films.